

Great Strategy. Now Where Do We Take It?

A GTM Masterclass on Channels, Customer Journeys & Growth

Rahul Tripathi

Head of Digital Marketing, Airtel Business

Last Session, We Answered

WHO	WHY US	WHAT DO WE SAY
Which segment are we pursuing?	What makes us the right choice?	What's the core message?

Now comes the uncomfortable question: **Where exactly do we say it?** Because even brilliant messaging fails if it appears in the wrong place. Advertising everywhere — Google, Instagram, LinkedIn, Snapchat, WhatsApp, influencers, cold calls — doesn't give you a GTM strategy. It gives you a **media shopping list.**

What Is Go-To-Market?

A GTM plan connects five essential elements into one coherent motion:

1

Audience

WHO are we pursuing?

2

Proposition

WHAT value do we offer?

3

Channel

WHERE will we reach them?

4

Activity

HOW do we execute?

5

Measurement

HOW WILL WE KNOW it worked?

Don't Start With the Channel

The wrong starting question: *"Should we run Meta ads?"* The right sequence follows customer logic, not marketer preference.



Who is the customer?

What behaviour?

Does demand exist?

Where do they spend attention?

Which channel fits journey?

Channel follows customer behaviour — not marketer preference.



The Big GTM Distinction

Capture vs. Generate Demand

This is one of the most important concepts in GTM strategy. The channel you choose depends entirely on which mode applies to your customer right now.

Capture Demand

The customer **already knows** they have a problem and may need a solution. They are actively searching.

Your job: **intercept existing intent.**

Example: "Best CRM for small business" — high intent search, ready to buy.

Generate Demand

The customer may not recognise the problem, doesn't know your solution exists, and isn't currently searching.

Your job: **create awareness → interest → need.**

You must educate before you can sell. This requires patience and different metrics than capture.

FitFataak: Same Product, Different Customer State

Capture Demand

Someone searches *"high protein snacks online"* — demand exists. **Google Search captures it.**

Generate Demand

Millions of office workers aren't searching for salvation from the 4 PM samosa — but they feel it. Instagram content showing *"That moment when the office samosa arrives at 4:30..."* **generates demand.**

Same product. Different customer state. Different channel role.



Search vs. Social

Search

Customer says: *"I need something."*
Brand responds: *"Here we are."*

Strong for: existing intent, problem-aware customers, product comparison, high-intent queries.

Social

Brand says: *"You might need this."*
Customer says: *"Hmm... actually, yes."*

Strong for: discovery, awareness, creating desire, visual storytelling, repeated exposure.

Neither is automatically better. **They solve different jobs.**

Channel ≠ Platform

Think about channels based on **behaviour**, not logos. Every channel operates at a different level of intent, attention, trust, and scale.



Search

User is actively looking. Highest intent.



Social Feed

User is discovering. Passive attention.



Email

You already have access to the person.



WhatsApp / DM

High-attention, direct, personalised.



Calling

Human conversation and qualification.



LinkedIn

Professional identity and business context.

A Channel Selection Framework

Before committing to a channel, evaluate it against five factors:

A — Audience

Is my customer actually there?

I — Intent

How close are they to solving the problem?

C — Complexity

How much explanation does my product require?

V — Value

What is the economic value of one conversion?

S — Scale

How many customers do I need to reach?

A-I-C-V-S — not a tattoo, but a useful thinking tool.



Product Economics Changes Channel Choice

Product A — ₹500 Headphones

Would you deploy a salesperson to personally call every potential buyer? Probably not. The unit economics make human-assisted channels unviable. Mass digital channels — social, search, marketplace — are far better fits.

The value of the transaction shapes which channels are commercially rational.

High Value = Different Channel Logic

Product B — ₹30 Lakh Enterprise Cybersecurity Solution

Would you rely solely on one Instagram ad saying *"Buy Now"*? Also no. At this price point and complexity level, buyers need education, trust-building, peer validation, and human conversation before they commit.

General principle: As value and complexity increase, human-assisted channels become more important — not less.



Product Type × Channel Logic

Match your product situation to the right channel mix. Audience behaviour can override the textbook — but this gives you a strong starting hypothesis.

Product Situation	Likely Channel Mix
Low-value + simple	Social, Search, Marketplace
Low-value + new category	Social, Creator, Video
High-value + existing demand	Search, Content, Sales
High-value + complex	LinkedIn, ABM, Email, Outreach
Existing customer base	Email, WhatsApp, CRM
Local immediate need	Search, Maps, Call

Audience Behaviour Is the Reality Check

Target: CFO

Rarely engages with entertainment-led Instagram ads for work solutions. Consumes industry reports. Responds to peer recommendations. Teams evaluate vendors.

GTM leans toward: Search, LinkedIn, thought leadership, email, events, direct outreach.

Target: College Student (₹1,000 Sneakers)

Highly active on visual social platforms. Influenced by creators and trends. Responds to discovery and peer social proof.

GTM leans toward: Instagram, Snapchat, creators, influencer content, marketplace.

Same channel strategy for both? Obviously not. **Follow attention and behaviour.**

Meta vs. Snapchat vs. LinkedIn

Don't select based on which platform is famous. Ask: **"What customer behaviour am I buying access to?"**

Meta

Broad reach, visual storytelling, interest-led discovery, retargeting across the purchase journey.

Snapchat

Younger audiences, visual-mobile behaviour, highly creative-led discovery campaigns.

LinkedIn

Professional identity, job role and company targeting, B2B buying context and decision-maker reach.

The audience and objective decide the fit — not convention.



Direct Outreach Is a Different Motion

Calls, WhatsApp, LinkedIn messages, InMail, and email outreach allow far greater personalisation — but personalisation costs time, data, effort, and sales capacity.

When Direct Outreach Makes Sense

Account value is high **and/or** the target universe is narrow. Calling 5,000 CFOs may be logical. Calling 5 million snack buyers isn't.

Think Portfolio, Not Single Channel

The question is rarely "which ONE channel?" A stronger GTM combines channels across the buying journey.

1

Demand Generation

LinkedIn content creates interest

2

Demand Capture

Google Search intercepts intent

3

Conversion

Landing page + email nurturing

4

Close

Sales call removes final friction

No single channel gets all the credit. **The portfolio does the work.**



Use AI for Channel Research

AI can help you formulate hypotheses about customer media behaviour, buying triggers, channel combinations, content formats, objections, and competitive approaches.

> "I am selling an enterprise cybersecurity product to Indian companies with 500+ employees. My primary buyers are CISOs and IT heads. Map plausible channels across demand generation, demand capture and conversion. Explain the role of each channel and assumptions that need validation."

The final phrase matters most: **"What assumptions need validation?"** — that's what separates strategy from guesswork.

Don't Ask AI "Which Channel Is Best?"

Instead, ask it to compare trade-offs. There is rarely one magical channel — GTM decisions are almost always trade-offs.

> "Compare Google Search, LinkedIn Ads, email outreach and cold calling for this audience using audience fit, intent, scalability, personalisation, cost and buying-stage relevance. Highlight trade-offs instead of selecting a winner."

Asking for a winner produces a shortcut. Asking for trade-offs produces a **strategy**.

Build a One-Page GTM Snapshot

After your research, organise the strategy into one concise, actionable page — not a 47-page document nobody opens again.

Target Segment

Who are we pursuing?

Core Problem

What pain are we solving?

Positioning

Why should they choose us?

Demand State

Generating or capturing?

Channels + Role

Where, and what job each does

Key Activities

What are we actually launching?

Primary KPI

How will we judge progress?

Example GTM Snapshot: FitFataak

Segment

Urban office professionals, 25–40

Problem

Unhealthy 4 PM snacking at work

Positioning

Indian taste + protein + convenience

Generate Demand

Instagram, creator content

Capture Demand

Google Search, marketplaces

Convert + Retain

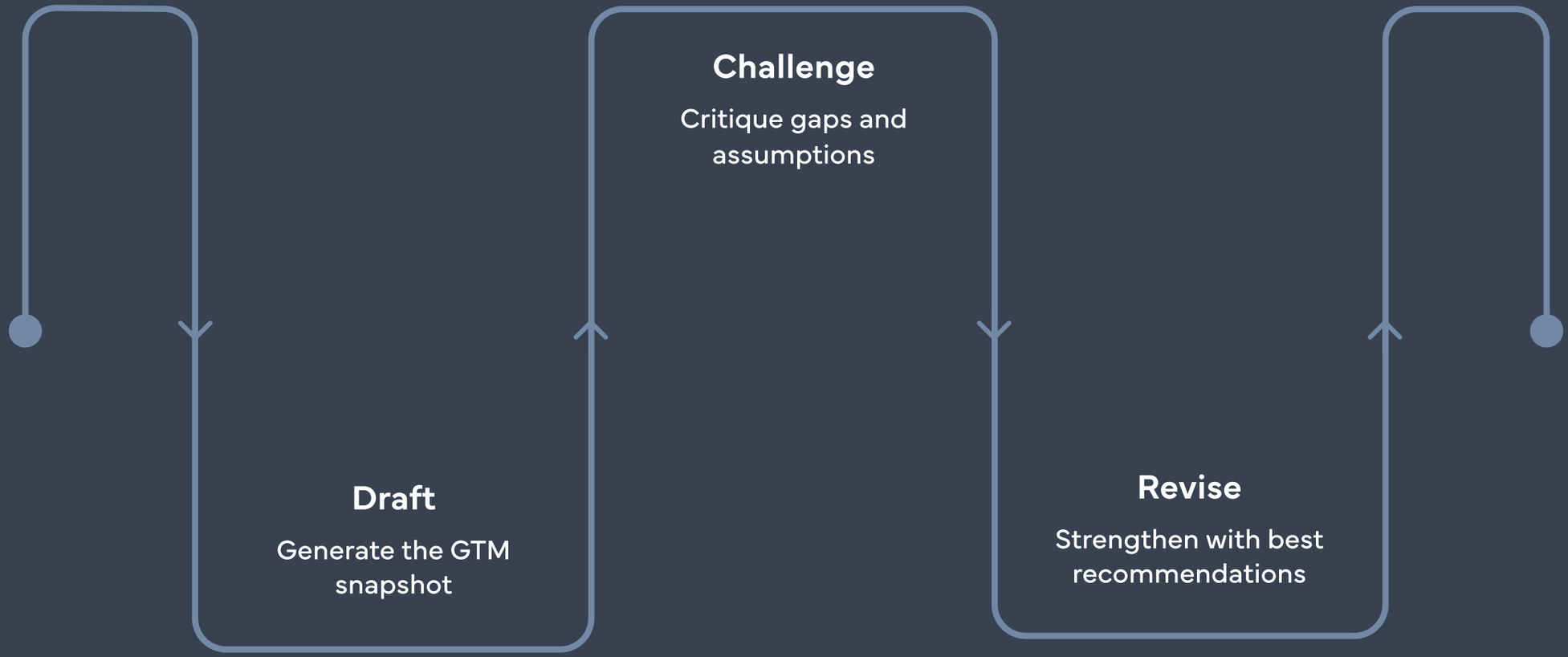
Retargeting, landing page, email/WhatsApp reorder journeys

Primary outcome: Repeatable customer acquisition. That's a GTM snapshot.

Now Ask AI to Attack the Plan

Don't stop once AI creates the strategy. Run a second prompt to stress-test it before committing resources.

> "Act as a sceptical growth leader. Review this GTM plan. Identify audience-channel mismatches, missing buying stages, over-reliance on one channel, weak assumptions and places where customer behaviour contradicts the strategy."



Not: Prompt → Copy → Presentation.

QUIZ

Test Your Understanding

Question 1

A new software category solves a problem that most buyers have not yet recognised. Which GTM approach is strongest initially?

A

Prioritise high-intent search terms and minimise educational activity

B ✓

Build category awareness while creating routes to capture emerging intent

C

Focus on retargeting users who have already reached the pricing page

D

Shift spending toward branded search before broadening communication

QUIZ

Question 2

A company sells ₹40 lakh cybersecurity contracts to a defined list of 600 enterprises. Which channel logic is most appropriate?

A

Maximise broad consumer reach before introducing direct seller engagement

B

Prioritise mass social reach because larger audiences reduce acquisition risk

C ✓

Combine targeted media, account content and personalised sales outreach

D

Use only search because active intent eliminates the need for nurturing

QUIZ

Question 3

A campaign receives strong social engagement but very few qualified buyers. Which diagnosis should be tested first?

A ✓

The channel may generate attention without sufficiently matching buying intent

B

The campaign necessarily requires more reach before conversions can emerge

C

The brand should remove qualification criteria to increase downstream volume

D

The same creative should be transferred unchanged to high-intent channels

QUIZ

Question 4

When assessing whether WhatsApp belongs in a GTM plan, which factor is most strategically relevant?

A

Whether competitors currently use WhatsApp as part of their marketing mix

B ✓

Whether the audience permits direct contact and the interaction adds value

C

Whether WhatsApp offers lower CPM than every available advertising platform

D

Whether the brand can replace email and sales calls entirely with messaging

QUIZ

Question 5

What is the strongest purpose of asking AI to critique an AI-generated GTM snapshot?

A

To obtain a second output without requiring additional customer information

B

To replace channel testing with a more detailed strategic recommendation

C ✓

To expose assumptions, contradictions and gaps before resources are committed

D

To ensure the final GTM plan contains every possible marketing channel

Rapid Revision: The GTM Chain

1

Customer

Who are we pursuing?

2

Demand State

Does it exist or need creating?

3

Channel

Where can we influence them?

4

Role

What should the channel accomplish?

5

KPI

How will we know it's working?

GTM Cheat Sheet

A complete GTM considers all four demand stages — not just acquisition.

Generate Demand

"I didn't know I needed this."



Capture Demand

"I am looking for this."

Convert Demand

"I am deciding whether to buy this."



Retain Demand

"Should I continue buying this?"

Getting Attention Is Not the Same as Getting a Customer

100,000 people see FitFataak. Fantastic. Did they buy? Not necessarily.

Customers move through stages. Someone who has never heard of you should not receive the same message as someone already comparing you with a competitor.

The journey changes. Therefore the message changes.



A Practical Customer Journey

Awareness

Who are you?

Decision

Why choose you?



Consideration

Why should I care?

Experience

Was it worth buying?

This sequence gives marketing a clear structure — each stage has a different customer question, message job, and success metric.



Awareness: Don't Ask for Marriage on the First Date

At awareness stage, the customer may not know your brand, your solution, or sometimes even the problem. Your job is to earn **attention + relevance.**

FitFataak Message

"That 4 PM office hunger hits differently."

Not: ~~"BUY 12 PACKS NOW."~~

Awareness Metrics

- Reach
- Video completion rate
- Qualified traffic
- Brand search growth
- Engaged audience creation

Consideration: Now Explain Why You

The customer knows the problem. Now real questions emerge — Is this good? What makes it different? Can I trust it? Is it worth the price?

What Marketing Needs

- Product benefits and comparisons
- Reviews and testimonials
- Educational content
- Proof and social validation

FitFataak: *"15g protein. Baked. Indian flavours."*

Consideration Metrics

- Product-page engagement
- Return visits
- Content consumption
- Lead quality
- Add-to-cart / enquiry behaviour

Decision: Reduce Risk

At decision stage, the question becomes: **"Why should I act now, and why with you?"** The message becomes increasingly specific and action-oriented.

Decision-Stage Tools

- Proof and case studies
- Offers and trials
- Demo or free consultation
- Pricing clarity
- FAQs and objection handling
- Direct sales conversation

Decision Metrics

- Conversion rate
- CAC
- Qualified opportunity rate
- Revenue
- Sales cycle length
- Cart completion



Same Customer. Different Message.

Showing "Book a Demo" to someone who doesn't yet understand the problem is one of the most common GTM mistakes.

Awareness

"Most breaches begin with compromised users."

Consideration

"See how behavioural security reduces identity-based risk."

Decision

"Compare deployment time, coverage and commercial impact."

Map the Journey Before Building the Campaign

For every stage, document the customer question, message job, and the action you want them to take. This becomes your campaign architecture.

Stage	Customer Question	Message Job	Desired Action
Awareness	Why care?	Problem relevance	Engage
Consideration	Why you?	Educate + differentiate	Explore
Decision	Why now?	Reduce risk	Buy / contact
Experience	Did it work?	Deliver value	Use
Retention	Continue?	Reinforce value	Repeat



Don't Launch Everything on Day One

Launching all channels simultaneously without sequencing is one of the most common — and expensive — GTM mistakes. Everything goes live. The landing page isn't ready. Analytics breaks. The sales team isn't briefed.

Sequence matters.

Example Launch Sequence

A disciplined launch is a phased progression — not a single chaotic day.

1

Foundation

Audience, value proposition, tracking, landing pages, CRM journeys, sales readiness

2

Create Awareness

Social, content, creators, video, thought leadership

3

Capture Intent

Search, retargeting, lead capture, high-intent content

4

Convert

Email, WhatsApp, sales, offers, demos

5

Optimise

Shift investment, improve messaging, retarget, scale winners

Launch is not a day. **It is a sequence.**

Build a Tight Timeline

Campaign plans without deadlines are just intentions. A timeline forces dependencies to become visible before they become problems.

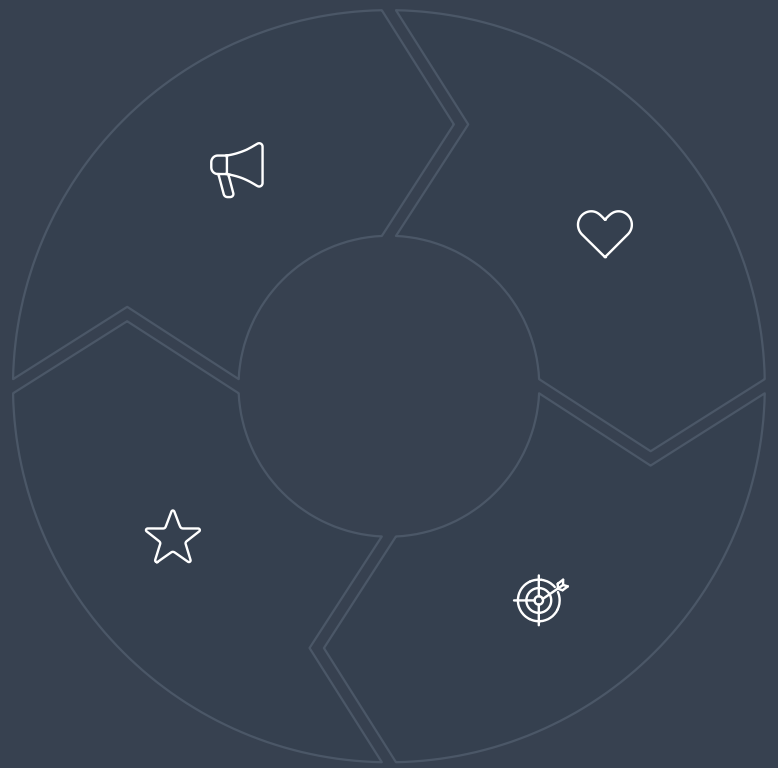


Sustained Acquisition ≠ Launch Spike

A bad campaign spikes at launch then collapses. Everybody asks: *"What next?"* A stronger acquisition engine continuously feeds the funnel at every level.

New Audiences

Fresh reach and discovery



Engaged Audiences

Warming up consideration

Customers → Repeat

Acquired and retained

High-Intent Audiences

Ready to decide

Marketing should behave more like an **engine** than a firecracker.

Every Stage Needs Its Own Success Metric

Do not judge everything using one metric. Different stages answer different questions.

Awareness

Reach, relevant engagement, video completion, brand interest

Consideration

Engaged sessions, content consumption, return visits, qualified leads

Decision

Conversion rate, CAC, opportunities, revenue

Retention

Repeat purchase, usage, churn rate, retention rate, customer lifetime value

Vanity Metrics vs. Diagnostic Metrics

"We got 2 million impressions." Wonderful. What did they do? Metrics should help you diagnose where the system leaks — not just celebrate reach.

High impressions + low clicks

Possible relevance or message problem

High clicks + low conversion

Possible landing page or offer problem

High leads + low sales

Possible qualification, product, or sales issue

Good acquisition + poor retention

Possible product or customer-fit problem



Marketing Doesn't End at Acquisition

Customer purchases. Marketing team: *"Great job, everyone."* No. Post-acquisition determines whether growth is actually sustainable.

Activation

Did they actually start using the product?

Usage

Are they engaging with it regularly?

Retention

Are they staying? What's the churn rate?

Repeat + Expansion

Are they buying again and spending more?

Acquisition brings a customer in. **Retention determines how valuable that customer becomes.**

Example: Two Campaigns

Which campaign is better? You cannot confidently answer using CAC alone.

Campaign A

CAC = ₹500
10,000 customers acquired
70% never purchase again

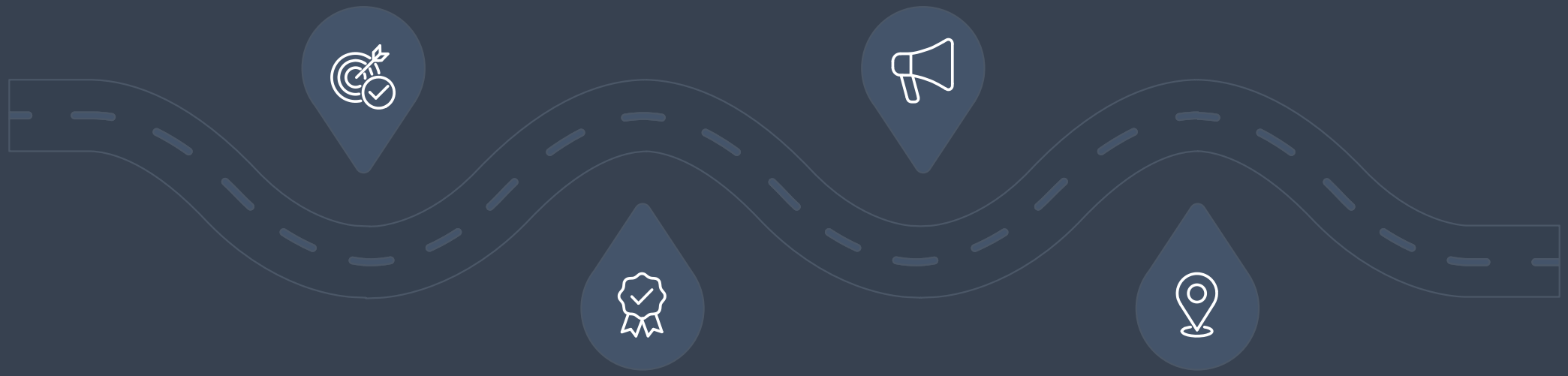
Campaign B

CAC = ₹700
8,000 customers acquired
60% purchase repeatedly

To judge properly, you need: repeat rate, retention, revenue per customer, margin, and lifetime value. **Cheap acquisition can become expensive growth.**

The Complete Growth Journey

This is the full marketing system built across our two sessions — from identifying the customer to creating continued value.



Identify

Pinpoint target customers

Communicate

Craft core messaging

Position

Clarify why choose us

Activate

Reach audiences where they are

QUIZ

Test Your Understanding

Question 1

A campaign produces strong awareness but few users later enter consideration. What should the team investigate first?

A ✓

Whether awareness messaging creates relevance and a logical next customer action

B

Whether decision-stage discounts can compensate for weak mid-funnel engagement

C

Whether total impressions should increase before judging consideration behaviour

D

Whether acquisition reporting should exclude users who did not convert immediately

QUIZ

Question 2

A SaaS campaign generates many qualified trials, but most users stop using the product within two weeks. Which metric deserves greater attention?

A

Impression frequency among people who have never visited the product website

B ✓

Activation and early usage behaviour among newly acquired trial customers

C

Click-through rate for awareness advertisements during the initial launch period

D

Search impression share for high-intent keywords used before the trial begins

QUIZ

Question 3

Why should campaign messaging change between awareness and decision stages?

A ✓

Each stage represents different customer questions, information needs and perceived risks

B

Each stage requires a completely different brand positioning and customer segment

C

Decision-stage buyers respond only to price while awareness buyers respond to emotion

D

Awareness communication should avoid product benefits until every customer knows the brand

QUIZ

Question 4

A team launches paid media before tracking, landing pages and lead routing are fully ready. What is the main strategic risk?

A ✓

Initial demand may arrive before the system can capture, measure and process it effectively

B

Media platforms will permanently penalise the brand for changing campaign settings later

C

Awareness activity will always generate lower conversion than campaigns launched after sales

D

Customer acquisition cost becomes impossible to improve after the first week of campaigning

QUIZ

Question 5

Campaign X has lower CAC than Campaign Y but far worse repeat purchase and retention. What is the strongest conclusion?

A

Campaign X is superior because acquisition efficiency should dominate campaign evaluation

B

Campaign Y is superior because retention should always outweigh acquisition efficiency

C ✓

Neither can be judged properly without considering downstream customer economics and value

D

Both campaigns are equally effective because different funnel metrics cannot be compared

Rapid Revision: The Five Journey Questions

Your message, channel, and metric should all change in response to the customer's current question.



Retention

"Should I stay / buy again?"



Experience

"Did I receive value?"



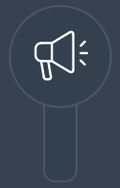
Decision

"Why should I choose you now?"



Consideration

"Why should I consider you?"



Awareness

"Why should I care?"

The Funnel Measurement Cheat Sheet

Don't ask one metric to explain the whole journey. Each stage has its own measurement language.

Awareness

Measure: Attention — reach, impressions, brand interest

Consideration

Measure: Engagement / intent — sessions, content, return visits

Decision

Measure: Conversion — CAC, revenue, opportunities

Experience

Measure: Activation / usage — onboarding, product engagement

Retention

Measure: Repeat / churn — LTV, repeat rate, churn rate